Name: _____ **Period:** _____ **Date:** _____

Topic 3.9 Guided Notes: Social, Cognitive, and Neurological Factors in Learning

Unit 3: Development and Learning | AP Psychology

Directions: Read through the topic overview page below and fill in each blank as you go. Use the tables and activities to check your understanding, then head to the quiz link at the end to test yourself.

Source page: appsychreviewhub.com/overviews/topic3.9

Word Bank

Insight Learning	*Cognitive Maps*
Modeling	*Vicarious Conditioning*
Latent Learning	*Social Learning Theory*

1. Learning by Watching: Social Learning Theory

Albert Bandura challenged strict behaviorism by proposing _____, which argues that learning is a cognitive process that frequently occurs through observation, rather than requiring personal experience with a direct consequence.

At the heart of this theory is _____—the process of acquiring new behaviors by actively observing and imitating the actions of others. Research demonstrates that we don't just mimic anyone; the more similar a model is to the observer (in age, gender, or perceived status), the more likely the behavior is to be successfully learned and replicated.

Vicarious Consequences

We do not need to be personally punished to know a stove is hot. We can learn through _____, which occurs when an individual observes the consequences (either rewards or punishments) that another person receives for their behavior, and subsequently adjusts their own behavior accordingly. If you watch a classmate get praised for raising their hand, you become more likely to raise yours.

The Bobo Doll Experiment: Bandura's classic study showed that children who observed an adult aggressively hitting a Bobo doll were highly likely to imitate that exact aggressive behavior when placed in a room with the doll themselves.

Apply It: Modeling or Vicarious Conditioning?

Using the word bank above, identify which concept best matches each scenario.

#	Scenario	Concept
1	A new employee starts arriving fifteen minutes early every day after noticing that the employees who arrive early tend to get the best parking spots and friendliest greetings from the boss.	
2	After watching her older sister successfully tie her shoelaces using a specific looping technique, a little girl starts using that exact same technique herself.	

#	Scenario	Concept
3	A student starts raising her hand before speaking in class after noticing that a classmate who interrupted without raising his hand got firmly scolded by the teacher in front of everyone.	

2. Cognitive Factors: Thinking About Learning

Strict behaviorists believed that learning could not happen without a tangible reward. However, cognitive psychologists proved that our brains are constantly processing and storing information in the background, even when there is no immediate incentive to do so.

Latent Learning and Cognitive Maps

A classic example of hidden learning is _____—learning that occurs without any immediate reinforcement or obvious demonstration. This knowledge remains hidden in the background but becomes instantly apparent the moment there is a motivation or reward to show it.

Latent learning is often demonstrated through the creation of _____, which are internal, mental representations of the layout of physical spaces or environments. For example, if you walk around a new school for a week without paying much attention, you are subconsciously building a cognitive map. You might not demonstrate this knowledge until a teacher offers you a piece of candy to quickly run a pass to the main office—suddenly, you know exactly which hallways to take!

The "Aha!" Moment

Sometimes, learning doesn't happen gradually through shaping or repetition. _____ occurs when the solution to a problem suddenly becomes clear without any prior trial-and-error, association, consequence, or modeling present. This is the classic "aha" moment when the pieces of a puzzle simply snap together in your mind.

📺 *Video Notes: "The Bobo Beatdown" (Crash Course Psychology #12)*

Watch the video above, then answer each question below in your own words.

1. How does the video describe Bandura's Bobo doll experiment (the setup and the results), and why does it say the results challenged the behaviorist view of learning?

2. According to the video, why can't conditioning explain everything an animal learns? Use the oyster and pigeon examples.

3. How does the video's alcohol-treatment example show that thoughts and social context also shape learning?

4. How does the video use a new city and rat mazes to illustrate latent learning and cognitive maps?

5. What are observational learning and modeling, according to the video, and what animal and human examples does it give?

6. What are mirror neurons, how were they discovered, and what does the video conclude about the importance of models?

Apply It: Latent Learning, Cognitive Map, or Insight Learning?

Using the word bank above, identify which concept best matches each scenario.

#	Scenario	Concept
1	An employee who has worked in an office for months without ever needing to find the break room suddenly knows exactly where it is the first time a coworker invites her to lunch there.	
2	After wandering around an unfamiliar museum for an hour just looking at exhibits, a visitor can later sketch a fairly accurate floor plan of the building from memory, showing where each wing and exhibit hall was located.	
3	A chess player stares at a complicated board for several minutes, failing to find a good move, until suddenly the winning sequence of moves flashes into her mind all at once, with no further testing of other moves needed.	

3. Don't Trip Up! (Common Misconceptions)

⚠️ Vicarious Conditioning vs. Operant Conditioning: It is easy to mix these up on the AP Exam! Remember that in Operant Conditioning, the learner is the one who directly receives the consequence. In _____, the learner is just a bystander watching someone else receive the consequence.

4. Quick Check: Review Questions

Circle the best answer for each question below.

1. A young boy watches his older brother confidently ride a skateboard down a ramp and then attempts to copy the exact same movements and technique himself the next day. This process of acquiring new behaviors by actively observing and imitating others is called:

- **A.** Vicarious Conditioning
- **B.** Latent Learning
- **C.** Modeling
- **D.** Insight Learning

2. In Bandura's classic study, children who watched an adult aggressively punch, kick, and yell at an inflatable doll were later placed in a room with that same doll themselves. What did researchers find regarding the children's subsequent behavior?

A. The children exclusively displayed gentle, caring behavior toward the doll regardless of what they had observed

B. The children were highly likely to imitate the exact same aggressive behaviors they had observed

C. The children completely ignored the doll and showed no interest in interacting with it at all

D. The children only became aggressive if they were personally and directly rewarded for hitting the doll themselves

3. A student spends several weeks casually wandering through an unfamiliar mall with no reason to memorize its layout, but when a friend later offers to pay for lunch if she can locate a specific store quickly, she immediately knows exactly which route to take. This demonstrates that learning had already occurred even without any reward at the time, a phenomenon called:

A. Modeling

B. Insight Learning

C. Vicarious Conditioning

D. Latent Learning

4. After walking through the hallways of a new school for several days without paying much conscious attention, a student subconsciously builds an internal, mental representation of the school's physical layout, including where each classroom and exit is located. This internal mental representation of a physical space is called a:

A. Mental Set

B. Schema

C. Cognitive Map

D. Prototype

5. After struggling for a long time to figure out how to move a heavy couch through a narrow doorway, a man suddenly realizes, with no new information or trial-and-error involved, that if he simply tilts the couch at a specific angle, it will fit through perfectly. This sudden "aha" moment where a solution becomes instantly clear is called:

A. Latent Learning

B. Vicarious Conditioning

C. Shaping

D. Insight Learning

✅ Check Your Progress

Done with your notes? Head over to the Quiz to test what you've learned:

https://appsychreviewhub.com/quiz

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